Dr Sumantra Maitra, FRHistS

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PROFILE

Policy scholar with a PhD in History and International Relations, working on the impact-heavy problems of statecraft: grand strategy, alliance management, escalation, and the strategic consequences of emerging technology. Regular user of Frontier AI, including Claude, GPT, and Muse in analytical workflow; independent research program on AI consciousness, model welfare, and AI-risk debates (2026–Present).

Noted for his contribution to "burden shifting" within NATO, adopted by the National Security Strategy, from his doctrine of "Dormant NATO".

AI, TECHNOLOGY, AND STATECRAFT: SELECTED ONGOING WORK

- "Star Wars and the dawning techno-empire," *Engelsberg Ideas*, October 13, 2026 — on the logical endpoint of technological concentration: imperial, technologically advanced, and undemocratic.
- "The Star Wars Theory of AI Adoption," working paper, ~5,000 words, October 2026 — four propositions on how AI adoption concentrates elite power and erodes middle-class bargaining power, with sector projections.
- "Our Star Wars Future," essay, October 2026 — on technology, governance, and the end of democracy.
- "The Drone Revolution and American Power: Mass, Affordability, and Strategy in an Offense-Dominant Age," analysis and proposal stage, October 2026.
- "Transatlantic Futures," analysis and proposal stage on technology equilibrium between the EU and the US, October 2026.

CURRENT APPOINTMENTS

- **Advisor,** Congressional Greenland Caucus, USA (2025–Present)
- **Washington Fellow,** Institute for Peace and Diplomacy (2026–Present)
- **Elected Fellow,** Royal Historical Society (RHS), UK (elected 2025; lifetime fellowship)

FORMER POSITIONS

- **Director of Research and Outreach,** American Ideas Institute, Washington, DC (2022–2026) — content and editorial decisions, major donor budgeting, research and outreach, management of Constitutional Fellowship programs, and Congressional liaisons.
- **Senior Fellow,** Center for Renewing America (2022–2026)
- **National Security Fellow,** Center for the National Interest, USA (2021–2023)
- **Non-Resident Fellow,** James G. Martin Center for Academic Renewal, USA (2020–2022)
- **Associate Fellow (2022**–2025); Early Career Researcher member (2021–2022), Royal Historical Society, UK

MAJOR THEORETICAL CONTRIBUTIONS

- Coined and defined the **"Dormant NATO" doctrine** — first formulated in a 2023 policy brief; full statement in "The Best NATO Is a Dormant NATO," *Foreign Affairs*, November 4, 2024. Proponent of burden-shifting in theory and practice; incorporated into the National Security Strategy, 2025.
- A new nuclear posture for multipolarity — "Exploring the Contours of an America First Nuclear Strategy," *American Affairs*, November 2025.
- Drones and the offense–defense balance — Center for Renewing America policy brief, 2024.

Selected academic discussion of the "Dormant NATO" doctrine:

- *"By 2024, dormant NATO had become one of multiple reference points in the debate on the future of the Atlantic Alliance"* — Sten Rynning, H-Diplo/RJISSF Article Review 174, June 2025
- Brian Blankenship's reply in the Jervis Forum Roundtable 17-2 on *The Burden-Sharing Dilemma* (H-Diplo/RJISSF, September 2025) engages Maitra's "dormant NATO" concept directly, citing his 2023 Center for Renewing America brief.

EDUCATION

- **PhD, History and International Relations,** University of Nottingham, UK (2016–2020) — funded by the Vice-Chancellor's International Scholarship for Research Excellence. Thesis: "Neorealism and Russian Balancing in Europe" (2019).
- **Master of International Studies,** University of Otago, New Zealand (2012–2013) — Distinction in International Politics and Global Economy; High Credit in research thesis; Coursework Master's Scholarship, 2012.
- **MA in Journalism and Mass Communication,** Sikkim Manipal University, India (2010) — Grade A.

PUBLISHED BOOK

- *Sources of Russian Aggression* (Lexington Books / Rowman & Littlefield, May 2024). PhD thesis, published in book form.

Praise for *Sources of Russian Aggression*:

- *"This is a truly excellent study of Russian foreign policy since the Cold War"* — John J. Mearsheimer, University of Chicago (publisher's blurb)
- *"Sumantra Maitra's work looks carefully, and from a realist perspective, at actual Russian behavior, its implications, and the conclusions we can draw from it, and all without the strong ideological spectacles that so many bring to the issues"* — Lord Frost (publisher's blurb)
- *"Sumantra Maitra's book attempts to address a simple but timely question: when does Moscow choose war, and when, in a similar situation, does Moscow refuse to pull the trigger"* — Russell Vought, Center for Renewing America (publisher's blurb)
- *"But Sumantra Maitra's new book turns the tables on this view"* — Yoram Hazony, Edmund Burke Foundation (publisher's blurb)
- *"Sumantra Maitra's study, The Sources of Russian Aggression, is a serious book. Rich, well-organised, precise and nicely contentious"* — Patrick Porter, The Critic, December 2024/January 2025
- *"To any reader who wants to get a deeper understanding of Russian aggression, its causes, and its consequences, this is the place to start"* — Matthew Bryant, The National Interest, August 2024
- *"The strategic assumptions about Russian denial strategy in their near-abroad made by the author hold up"* — Responsible Statecraft
- *"Maitra shows how Moscow's actions have been quite predictable and rational within a realist framework"* — Mises Institute
- *"Sumantra Maitra's book is a notable exception. He argues that Russia seems to behave as realist theory would predict any great power would behave"* — "Putin's Preventive War," International Security 49(3), Winter 2024/25

Also reviewed in the Naval War College Review 79(1), 2026.

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

- "Exploring the Contours of an America First Nuclear Strategy," *American Affairs*, November 2025.
- "Whither Goest Thou, International Relations?" *Academic Questions* 35(1), Spring 2022.
- "A Lost Opportunity of a Grand Bargain: Security Architecture Between NATO and Russia," *International Journal* (Canadian International Council), Spring 2022.
- "NATO Enlargement, Russia, and Balance of Threat," *Canadian Military Journal* 21(3), Summer 2021, pp. 35–46.

- Assessment: “Russian Military Strategy, Operational Tactics and Objective in Syria,” *Centre for Land Warfare Studies*, 2017.
- “Realism in Russian Foreign Policy: The Crimean Case,” *Center for Land Warfare Studies Journal*, 2014, pp. 116–128.
- “Understanding Putin’s Foreign and Economic Policy Correlation,” *The Nottingham Economic Review* 3, 2014, pp. 28–31.
- “US Foreign Policy: Back to Realism,” *International Affairs Review* 23(2), 2013.
- “Women and War: Women in Combat and the Internal Debate in the Field of Gender Studies,” *Global Policy* 2, 2013.

ESSAYS AND BOOK CHAPTERS

- “A Better Greenland Deal,” *Foreign Affairs*, January 2026.
- “The Best NATO Is a Dormant NATO,” *Foreign Affairs*, November 4, 2024.
- “How Drones Are Changing War: Cheaper Technology Means a Return to Offense Dominance,” *The American Conservative* 23(1), 2024, pp. 34–39.
- “Reactionary Vanguardism,” *The National Interest* 181, 2022, pp. 56–62.
- “Rise of a Counter-Elite” [also published as “A Grand Strategy of Restraint Needs a ‘Counter Elite’”], *The National Interest* 177, 2022, pp. 52–60.
- “Returning to the Lansdowne Doctrine,” *Law & Liberty*, August 22, 2022.
- “Old Wine, New Bottle” (with Patrick Porter), *The National Interest*, 2021, pp. 41–47.
- “The Bear and Maidan Affair,” *The National Interest*, 2020, pp. 62–68.
- “Europe First,” *The National Interest*, 2020, pp. 92–96.
- “‘If I Want to Hold Seminars on the Topic of Empire, I Will Do So Privately’: An Interview with Nigel Biggar,” *Quillette*, 2018.
- “The Deceptively Romantic Historical Musings of the Russian Foreign Minister,” *War on the Rocks*, April 6, 2016.
- “Europe, the Rationale of Burden Shifting, and the Promise of Germany,” chapter in *New Visions for Grand Strategy*, eds. Emma Ashford and Nevada Joan Lee, 2025. [Editors and publisher to be confirmed.]

SELECTED POLICY BRIEFS

- “Dormant NATO,” *Center for Renewing America*, 2023.
- “What an America First Nuclear Strategy Entails,” *Center for Renewing America*, 2026.
- Primer: “Thematic Similarities Between the New National Security Strategy and National Defense Strategy,” *Center for Renewing America*, 2026.
- Primer: “An America First Drone Strategy,” *Center for Renewing America*, 2025.
- “Seeking Equilibrium in East Europe: Burden Shifting in the Baltics,” *Center for Renewing America*, 2022.
- “NATO Expansion for Finland and Sweden: A Dangerous and Unnecessary Distraction from US Interests,” *Center for Renewing America*, 2022.

CONFERENCE PAPERS, KEYNOTES, AND PANELS

- “Towards a Reformed NATO,” Washington, DC, 2024.
- “Russian Reaction to NATO Expansion,” Washington, DC, 2024.
- “Dormant NATO and NATO Reform,” Ludovika University, Budapest, 2024.
- Book talk: Sources of Russian Aggression, Budapest, 2024.
- Chair, “National Realism and Foreign Policy” panel, London, 2023.
- “The Iraq War at 20 Years,” Washington, DC, 2023.
- “Defensive Realism, American Grand Strategy and Balancing China,” Miami, 2022.
- Roundtable, Liberty Conference, Fort Myers, 2022.

- Keynote, “Realpolitik 2022: Implications for Global Trade and Precious Metals When Great Powers Collide,” Gold Forum, Denver/Zürich, 2022.
- “Applied Realism, American Grand Strategy, and Strategic Interests in the European Balance,” working paper, Center for Security Studies, ETH Zürich, 2021.
- “Assessing Russian Military Aggression in Europe in Light of Balance of Threat Theory,” Government and Society PGR Annual Conference, POLSIS, University of Birmingham, 2019.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- **Instructor, Toolbox of American Statecraft** — for Hill and Senate staffers and fellows, American Moment Fellowship, Washington, DC (2022–Present).
- **Constitutional Fellows Program,** *The American Conservative* (2023–Present).
- **Teaching Assistant,** University of Nottingham (2017–2019) — Problems in Global Politics; Understanding Global Politics.
- **Tutor,** University of Otago (2012–2013) — Introduction to International Relations (POLS 104); New Zealand Foreign Policy (POLS 213).

ACADEMIC SCHOLARSHIPS AND HONOURS

- Vice-Chancellor’s Research Excellence PhD Scholarship (International), University of Nottingham, UK (2016–2019).
- Coursework Master’s Scholarship, University of Otago, NZ (2011–2012).

SELECTED PROJECT LEADS

- Lead Researcher and Project Coordinator, “Blueprints for Reform” project, James G. Martin Center, USA (2020–2022).
- Researcher, Free Speech in West Virginia project — James G. Martin Center / Foundation for Individual Rights in Education, USA (2021–2022).

MEDIA, COMMENTARY, AND PROFESSIONAL ASSOCIATIONS

- **Columnist:** Engelsberg Ideas (UK), The Critic (UK), The American Conservative (US), The Spectator (UK).
- **Occasional analyst and commentator:** Fox & Friends First, CBS Evening News, USA.
- **Advisory Council,** The Free Speech Union, UK.
- **Associate Member,** Heterodox Academy (2017–2019).
- SEED Business Studentship, Dunedin, NZ — Upstart SEED Business Project (2013).

ACADEMIC BOOK REVIEWS

- Review: “Russian Conservatism: Managing Change Under Permanent Revolution,” *International Affairs* 98(1), 2022, pp. 342–344.
- Review: “The Second World Wars: How the First Global Conflict Was Fought and Won,” *International Affairs* 94(4), 2018, pp. 928–929.
- Review: “After the Enlightenment: Political Realism and International Relations in the Mid-Twentieth Century,” *International Affairs* 94(2), 2018, pp. 427–428.
- Review: “More on War,” *International Affairs* 93(6), 2017, pp. 1480–1481.
- Review: “Black Wind, White Snow: The Rise of Russia’s New Nationalism,” *International Affairs* 93(1), 2017, pp. 221–222.
- Review: Louis Sell, “From Washington to Moscow: US–Soviet Relations and the Collapse of the USSR,” *International Affairs* 92(6), 2016, pp. 1520–1521.
- Review: Bobo Lo, “Russia and the New World Disorder,” *Political Studies Review* 14(4), 2016, p. 583.

LANGUAGES

Native English. Fluent in Hindi and Bengali. Minimal French.

References available on request.